websites in Myanmar belonged to ‘legitimate media’. By 2017, under the impact of Instant Articles, ‘legitimate media’ was down to just two websites out of the top ten. By 2018, all top ten websites were ‘fake news and clickbait websites’.

The study concluded that because of the launch of Instant Articles ‘clickbait actors cropped up in Myanmar overnight. With the right recipe for producing engaging and evocative content, they could generate thousands of US dollars a month in ad revenue, or ten times the average monthly salary – paid to them directly by Facebook.’ Since Facebook was by far the most important source of online news in Myanmar, this had enormous impact on the overall media landscape of the country: ‘In a country where Facebook is synonymous with the Internet, the low-grade content overwhelmed other information sources.’[18] Facebook and other social media platforms didn’t consciously set out to flood the world with fake news and outrage. But by telling their algorithms to maximise user engagement, this is exactly what they perpetrated.

Reflecting on the Myanmar tragedy, Pwint Htun wrote to me in July 2023, ‘I naively used to believe that social media could elevate human consciousness and spread the perspective of common humanity through interconnected pre-frontal cortexes in billions of human beings. What I realize is that the social media companies are not incentivized to interconnect pre-frontal cortexes. Social media companies are incentivized to create interconnected limbic systems – which is much more dangerous for humanity.’

THE ALIGNMENT PROBLEM

I don’t want to imply that the spread of fake news and conspiracy theories is the main problem with all past, present and future computer networks. YouTube, Facebook and other social media platforms claim that since 2018 they have been tweaking their algorithms to make them more socially responsible. Whether this is true or not is hard to say, especially because there is no universally accepted definition of ‘social responsibility’.[19] But the specific problem of polluting the information sphere in pursuit of user engagement can certainly be solved. When the tech giants set their hearts on designing better algorithms, they can usually do it. Around 2005, the